The 22nd Degree – Knight Royal Axe, Prince of Libanus



The apron is white, lined and bordered with purple. In the middle is embroidered a round table, on which are mathematical instruments and unrolled plans. On the flap is a serpent with three heads, denoting idleness, the body from which issues the three vices symbolized by the heads: drunkenness, impurity and gaming. By these vices many youths have been lost and many great nations have sunk into ignoble imbecility and shameful bondage.

The order is a broad, rainbow–colored ribbon, lined with purple. It is worn as a collar or may be worn as a sash, from right to left.

The jewel, suspended from the collar, is a gold axe and handle, the symbol of the great agent of civilization and improvement. Troops armed with this weapon have conquered barbarism. Under its blows the primeval forests disappear; the farmer displaces the wild hunter; to the rude barbarism of the early ages succeed

settled society, laws and all the arts that refine and elevate mankind. The axe is nobler than the sword. Masonry hews at those mighty trees, intolerance, bigotry, superstition, uncharitableness and idleness, thereby letting in the light of truth and reason upon the human mind, which these vices have darkened for centuries. The letters on the top are the initials of Noah and Solomon; those on the handle, of Libanus and Tsidunian; those on one side of the blade, of Adoniram, Kuros, Darius, Zerubbabel, Nehemiah and Azra; and those on the other side, of Shem, Kham, Yapheth, Moses, Aholiab and Betselal. These names represent the various places and persons significant in the use of the cedars of Lebanon for "Holy Enterprises"; examples include Noah's Ark, the Ark of the Covenant, Solomon's Temple, and the rebuilding of Jerusalem and the Temple by Zerubbabel.

DUTIES

Respect labor for its own sake, and do work.

LESSONS

Work is the mission of man.

FOR REFLECTION

If one finds for himself esteem in his labors, does the prestige associated with his labors matter?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

The cedars of Lebanon, carpenter's tools: saw, plane and axe.

Despite the mention of King Solomon's Temple in this degree we are not returning to the Hiramic Legend. The time is the Middle Ages, for the candidate comes dressed as a German (or Prussian) Knight, a crusader in the Holy Land. He has traveled to Mount Libanus (or Lebanon) to obtain the degree of Prince of Libanus.

According to the ritual, this degree was learned by the Crusaders from the Druses (or Druzes), an Islamic sect inhabiting the area. The Druse are a mystical group characterized by an eclectic system of doctrines and by a remarkable cohesion and loyalty among its members. They permit no conversion, either

from or to their religion, and no intermarriage. While very little is known about the Druse, because of their secrecy, it is believed a number of groups accepted this religions system but only the Druse of Lebanon survive. Their religious doctrines appear to be an amalgamation of Christianity, Judaism, Islam, Gnosticism and other beliefs prevalent about 1000 A.D. They have various degrees of initiation recognizing the elite or ‘knowers’ who participate fully and have access to all the Druse religious doctrines. Simplicity of attire, self-denial, temperance and irreproachable moral conduct are prerequisites to join this group of elites.

This degree explains that the Druse perpetuated an institution originating in Rome about 700 B.C. called Colleges of Artificers which are simply described as operative groups of artisans, much as carpenters or goldsmiths. Parallels between these Colleges and Freemasonry exist which have caused some scholars to trace the roots of Masonry to them.

According to a legend, the Tyrians or Phoenicians were ever ready to aid the Israelites in their holy enterprises. The tie between them was the mysteries, into which the principal persons of both nations were initiated; Moses necessarily received them in Egypt, before he could marry the daughter of a priest of Heliopolis. These mysteries, modified by Solomon, or perhaps at an earlier date by Joshua or even Moses, became in some respects like Masonry, such as it was practiced at the building of the Temple, and such as it has in part come down to us. Hiram, King of Tyre in Phoenicia, and Hiram Abif, whose father was a Phoenician and not a Jew, were likewise initiates. Hence, the intimate connection between them and Solomon, bound together by obligation, as Masons are today.

Upon Mount Lebanon the College of Artificers was established, like those of Rome. These artificers everywhere maintained their rights and privileges and had their signs and words, by which to recognize each other. Solomon himself, whose wisdom necessarily gave him a true idea of labor, built a palace on the mountain, to which he often repaired to inspect the progress of the work.

Although only a legend, the ritual further suggests that the Colleges of Rome may have been derived from the ancient people who inhabited the Mount

Lebanon area and supplied cedar for the building of Noah's Ark, the Ark of the Covenant and Solomon's Temple. This legend accounts for bodies of this degree being called Colleges, the events in the drama and much of its symbolism.

CEREMONY

The drama takes place in two apartments. The first is plain but sufficiently furnished to represent a carpenter's workshop on Mount Lebanon. The second room is the Council Room of the Round Table. It is hung with red, representative of fervency and zeal. In the East is the altar; upon it are the Bible, square and compasses and an axe. In the center of this apartment is a round table at which the brethren sit—such a table denotes equality as it did for the knights of King Arthur.

With the reception of the candidate as a Prussian Knight, the seemingly strange symbolism associated with the famed cedars of Mount Lebanon becomes understandable. In the opening of the degree the cedars wait to be felled and in the closing they have been felled. In the symbolism of the ancients, and as often seen in Masonry, the tree (not necessarily the cedar) takes on special significance. The Tree of Life (mentioned in the 19th Degree), the Tree of Knowledge in Genesis, the Sephirotic Tree of the Kabbalah, the Cross as a Tree, the Oak of the Celts and others, all bring to mind positive images of consistency, growth, proliferation, generative and regenerative processes, and immortality.

The cedar is a large and particularly beautiful tree; the numerous Biblical references to it evidence this. During Biblical times, the cedar was especially abundant. It is a tall tree reaching heights of 100 feet and providing dense shade on dry sloping mountain sides. The cedar's beauty is enhanced by the production of purple cones, purple being a symbol of royalty. It has been called "the glory of Lebanon (Isaiah 35:2; 60:13) and "the tree(s) of the Lord" (psalms 104; 16). Zechariah says, "When the cedar falls, the fir, itself a noble tree, howls, as a vassal for his lord" (11:1–2). The cedar was used for masts on ships, beams, pillars and boards because of its height and strength. The wood is close grained, sound to the heart, fragrant, a pleasing color, indestructible by dry rot or borers.

It is said the cedar roof of the temple of Apollo lasted 1170 years. Simply, the cedars of Lebanon were considered noble, mighty and majestic trees of great importance.

The candidate seeks the privilege, by birth and rank, of becoming a Prince of Libanus. This is declared insufficient. He must lay aside his claims to any right to this degree by birth or rank in Masonry. To fell the cedar is to end privileges which result from birth and rank. Privilege must be earned by work. The candidate must divest himself of the jewels and adornments of his rank and labor among the work en, obtaining their unanimous vote to advance.

Since he has shown a true appreciation for the dignity of labor and learned to use the saw, plane and axe, the candidate is instructed on the symbolic meaning of the working tools of the carpenter. The saw symbolizes patience and determination; it teaches us that Masons, laboring for the improvement of the world and the cause of human progress, must be content to move slowly and painfully to success. Since the plane cuts down the inequalities of surfaces, it symbolizes Masonry which removes the prejudice of ignorance and aide to civilize mankind. The axe should remind the Mason of the march of civilization and progress which requires him to hew the poisonous trees of intolerance, bigotry, superstition, uncharitableness and idleness to let in the light of truth and reason upon the human mind.

LECTURE

In *Morals and Dogma,* we are taught that work is the mission of man– not a curse, but the fulfillment of life's purpose. Our daily labor, if fit and proper, receives the blessing of God. If the employer understands the dignity even of simple labor, then the employee will not be oppressed.

Respect labor for its own sake:

Sympathy with the great laboring classes, respect for labor itself, and resolution to do some good work in our day and generation, these are the lessons of this Degree, and they are purely Masonic (p. 340).

From first to last, Masonry is work. It venerates the Grand Architect of the Universe. It commemorates the building of the Temple. Its principal emblems are the working tools of Masons and Artisans. It preserves the name of the first worker in brass and iron as one of its pass–words. When the Brethren meet together, they are at labor. The Master is the overseer who sets the craft to work and gives them proper instruction. Masonry is the apotheosis of WORK (p. 340).

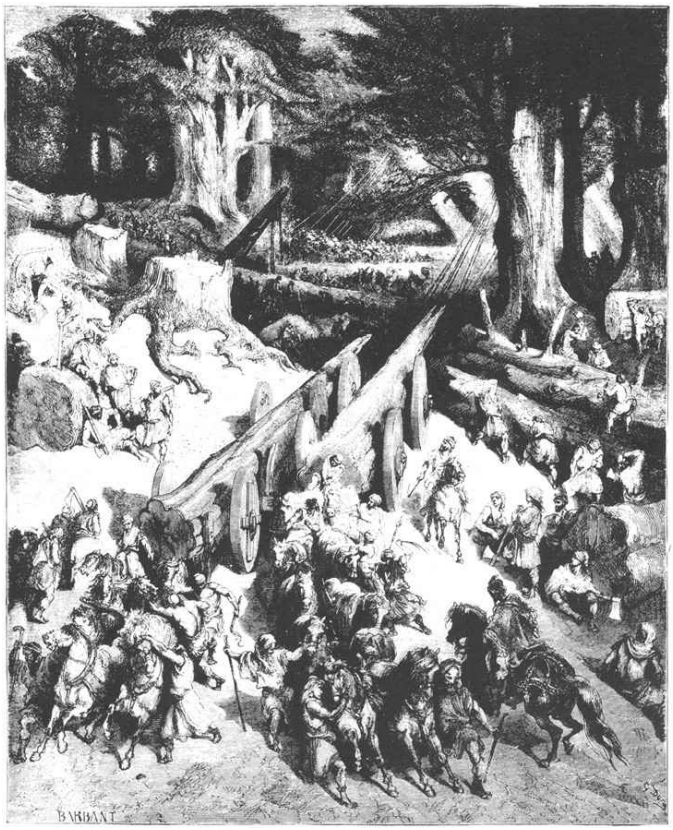
Whatsoever of morality and intelligence; what of patience, perseverance, faithfulness, of method, insight, ingenuity, energy; in a word, whatsoever of STRENGTH a man has in him, will lie written in the WORK he does. To work is to try himself against Nature and her unerring, everlasting laws: and they will return true verdict as to him. The noblest Epic is a mighty Empire slowly built together, a mighty series of heroic deeds, a mighty conquest over chaos. Deeds are greater than words. They have a life, mute, but undeniable; and grow. They people the vacuity of Time, and make it green and worthy (p. 341).

"Work; and therein have well–being," is the oldest of Gospels; unpreached, inarticulate, but ineradicable, and enduring forever. To make Disorder, wherever found, an eternal enemy; to attack and subdue him, and make order of him, the subject not of Chaos, but of Intelligence and Divinity, and of ourselves; to attack ignorance, stupidity and brute–mindedness, wherever found, to smite it wisely and unweariedly, to rest not while we live and it lives, in the name of God, this is our duty as Masons... (p. 342).

Duty is with us ever; and evermore forbids us to be idle. To work with the hands or brain, according to our requirements and our capacities, to do that which lies before us to do, is more honorable than rank and title. Ploughers, spinners and builders, inventors, and men of science, poets, advocates, and writers, all stand upon one common level, and form one grand, innumerable host, marching ever onward since the beginning of the world: each entitled to our sympathy and respect, each a man and our brother (p. 343).

The great author or artist only portrays what every man should be. He conceives, what we should do. He conceives, and represents moral beauty, magnanimity, fortitude, love, devotion, forgiveness, the soul's greatness. He portrays virtues, commended to our admiration and imitation (p. 349).

Masonry seeks to ennoble common life. Its work is to go down into the obscure and unsearched records of daily conduct and feeling; and to portray, not the ordinary virtue of an extraordinary life; but the more extraordinary virtue of ordinary life. What is done and borne in the shades of privacy, in the hard and beaten path of daily care and toil, full of uncelebrated sacrifices; in the suffering, and sometimes insulted suffering, that wears to the world a cheerful brow; in the long strife of the spirit, resisting pain, penury, and neglect, carried on in the inmost depths of the heart;—what is done, and borne, and wrought, and won there, is a higher glory and shall inherit a brighter crown (p. 350).



The Cedars Destined for the Temple
by Gustave Dore